

CORE FORMULA

Content: So the practical issue is that X happened, then Y changed, and now Z is uncertain. ->

Emotion: So it was not just inconvenient — it felt genuinely frustrating and unfair. -> **Meaning:** The part that seems to matter most is that it made you feel you were not being taken seriously. ->

Values: What I am hearing is that control and fairness matter more here than speed. -> **Decision:** So the choice is between a faster option with more uncertainty and a slower one with more confidence. -> **Loop-breaking:** I think we are circling two things — the decision itself, and how it was communicated.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Reflect back the one thing that matters most, then check it: "So the main thing is X, not just Y — have I got that right?"

BEST FOR

- Before giving advice, making a request, disagreeing or persuading
- After someone tells a long story or a complex, tangled situation
- When emotion, conflict or misunderstanding is in the room
- When several issues are knotted together
- When you want someone to feel genuinely understood, not just heard
- When a conversation is starting to loop or repeat
- Before closing a conversation or agreeing next steps
- In digital messages, where tone and intent are easily misread

PHRASE BANK

Quick defaults · Short openers

- "Let me check I have this right."
- "So the main thing is..."
- "The key issue sounds like..."
- "Have I got that right?"
- "What have I missed?"
- "Let me say it back to make sure."
- "What would you change in that summary?"

Warm and human · Warmth before responding

- "I want to make sure I am not missing the part that matters."
- "Let me see if I am hearing the real issue."
- "So it is not just X — it is also Y."
- "That sounds like the part that has stayed with you."
- "The thing underneath this seems to be..."
- "Before I respond, I want to be sure I have understood."
- "I want to get this right before I say anything else."

Conflict-safe · Objections and tension

- "Let me summarise your side before I give mine."
- "The part I am hearing is..."
- "You are not just objecting to X — you are worried about Y."

- "I think you are trying to protect..."
- "What I do not want to miss is..."
- "Tell me where I am off."

Professional / leadership · Meetings and decisions

- "Let me summarise the decision point."
- "There seem to be three issues here: X, Y and Z."
- "The trade-off appears to be..."
- "The risk you are flagging is..."
- "So the next step is..."
- "So the decision is between the faster, riskier option and the slower, safer one."
- "Can we check we are aligned before moving on?"

Persuasion / advice setup · Before you recommend

- "If I have understood your priority, it is..."
- "Given that the main concern is X, my suggestion would be..."
- "Before I offer a view, the goal seems to be..."
- "So any option needs to protect..."
- "If that is right, the simplest next step may be..."
- "Does that match what you care about most?"

Digital / text · One clean message

- "Quick recap so I know I have understood:"
- "My read: X is the issue, Y is the concern, Z is the next step. Correct me if I missed anything."
- "I think the main point is..."
- "Before I reply properly, am I right that the core issue is...?"
- "Tell me if I am oversimplifying."
- "My short version of what you said is..."

Repair / reset · When the summary misses

- "I think I summarised that too quickly. Let me try again."
- "I missed the emotional part there."
- "That summary was more my agenda than yours — sorry."
- "Let me back up. What I should have checked is..."
- "I am not trying to close this down; I just want to get it right."
- "Can you correct my version?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Uses the move mechanically or too often.
Better: Uses the smallest useful version, then listens.
Best: Uses it only when the cue is present, keeps the wording natural, and adjusts to the response.
2. Weak: Talks about the technique instead of doing it.
Better: Performs one clear behavioural move.
Best: Makes the move feel like ordinary, skilled conversation.
3. Weak: Summarises the facts and stops there.
Better: Adds the feeling or meaning underneath the facts.
Best: Names what it represented to them, in their own words, and invites correction.

DECISION TREE

If They have told a long or tangled story, or emotion is in the room.

Use the minimum viable move — reflect the core, then check it.

"So the main thing is X, not just Y — have I got that right?"

If Distress is present, not just information.

Validate the feeling before you summarise the content.

"That sounds really frustrating. Let me make sure I have got the heart of it."

If Your summary landed and they confirmed or corrected usefully.

Build on it — move toward advice, a request or next steps.

"That makes sense. Before I suggest anything, what would need to feel different?"

If They correct you twice or more and you are not updating.

Stop summarising; drop to one clarifying question in their words.

"Tell me where I am off — what is the part I keep missing?"

If A simple, urgent answer is what they actually need.

Skip the recap and give the direct answer or practical help.

"Short version: yes, let us do it — I will sort the details."

If You have already summarised once.

Do not repeat mechanically; switch to action or ordinary contribution.

"Okay, I think we are clear. Shall we agree the next step?"

SCENARIOS

Social conversation

Use the smallest natural version so they feel heard, not analysed. — "So it was a brilliant trip, but the ending soured it a bit?"

Professional discussion

Keep it concise and tie the recap to the task, decision or concern. — "So the blocker is the timeline, not the budget — is that the one to solve?"

Conflict or objection

Add validation and lower your speed; do not weaponise the recap. — "You are not just annoyed about the change — you feel it was decided without you."

Digital message

Write one clean sentence; avoid long explanations or stacked questions. — "Quick recap so I am sure I read this right: X is the issue, Y is the ask. Correct me if not."

Shy or guarded person

Make it lighter, more tentative and lower pressure. — "I might be off, but it sounds like the main thing is X?"

High-status or busy person

Keep the wording brief, grounded and useful. — "So the decision is X versus Y. Which do you want me to run with?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They need a direct answer urgently, not a recap
- The person needs safety, privacy, silence or practical help instead
- Physical safety or an emergency response takes priority
- A simple answer would do, and summarising would only slow things down
- You would be summarising to steer them toward your own agenda
- You have already summarised, and repeating it just makes them say it again

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cue

Through the day, notice three moments where a summary would help — a long story, tangled issues, or rising emotion. Just log them; do not act yet.

Day 2 — One-line content recaps

In three low-stakes conversations, reflect the core fact back in a single sentence and close with "Have I got that right?" Notice who corrects you.

Day 3 — Catch the feeling

Practise emotion and meaning summaries: "So it was not just inconvenient — it felt unfair." Aim underneath the facts at

least twice today.

Day 4 — Swap the close

Replace "Does that make sense?" with "What have I missed?" every time you check understanding. Feel the difference in how people respond.

Day 5 — Use it before you advise

In one work conversation, summarise their priority before offering any suggestion, decision or request. Build your recommendation on their words.

Day 6 — Practise the recovery

When a summary lands wrong, use a recovery line — "That was more my agenda than yours, sorry — let me back up." — and update to what they actually said.

Day 7 — Three-rep integration

Run all three in a day: one low-stakes recap, one professional recap before a decision, and one recovery after a missed read. Note what shifted.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I summarise their point, not my agenda?
- Did I catch the meaning or emotion, not just the facts?
- Was it shorter than their original point?
- Did I invite correction — and accept it without defending?
- Did I use the smallest version that would work?
- Did the summary actually move the conversation forward?